

STAMP OF A SCAM

The new Passport Seva project to ease delays raises security concerns as the Government moves to outsource operations to a private vendor

■ By Saurabh Shukla

It was dubbed a dream project for easing the passport woes of millions across the country. The aim was to end the long queues for securing a passport and introduce some biometric features to enhance security, but on the contrary the Passport Seva project, as it is called, runs the risk of compromising individual security and endangers national security as well. It raises fears of your personal details getting leaked or a terrorist getting hold of your identity from an old passport. With a private vendor developing a high-security passport software, this is the big question as the Government moves forward on the mega project which will outsource passport operations to a private vendor. "The whole project seems untenable. While we should look for ways to streamline the passport issuance system, the security of the process should not be compromised," says an MEA official. Even though several leading IT firms have submitted bids for the project, their opening has been postponed. While officials attribute the postponement to "technical issues", speculation is rife that the move is intended to benefit a particular bidder.

The Cabinet had okayed the project last year but it's the fingerprint which has raised doubts. According to the Cabinet note and the request for proposal, the project will lead to "outsourcing of front-end activities, not involving the sovereign functions of the Government. Under the new system,



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PASSPORT TO DISASTER ▶▶▶

With a private company developing the new passport software, personal details of passport holders and applicants could get leaked.

There are already teething troubles as opening of technical bids has been postponed twice without any reasons being assigned.

Objections were raised on the project by security agencies and passport officers at an inter-ministerial meet held in Hyderabad last year.

The project is being pushed in a haste and MEA's two junior ministers, E. Ahamed and Anand Sharma, are out of the loop.

The new system doesn't fix accountability for any mistake by the private vendor. Under the Passports Act, it is the government officials who are held responsible.

applications will be collected at 68 private passport centres. While the existing passport offices will facilitate back-end operations, all front-end operations that include capturing biometric features, verifying the authenticity of the application, and granting the passport will be handled by the private vendor, according to the request for proposals (RFP) circulated by the MEA. Sources say this would give the vendor enough scope to influence the passport issuing process. Once these proposals are implemented, passport applicants would need to shell out Rs 300-400 extra besides the usual fees for getting their passport applications processed.

With around 40 million Indian passport holders in the country, the earning for the bidder from various services—including renewal, additional booklets, renting out space at passport offices etc—is expected to be to the tune of several thousand crores.

Questions are also being raised, as under the proposal certain government officials will be posted for carrying out the index and blacklist checks at the passport centres which can compromise the process. Besides the key to the secret database of passport holders will have to be shared with the private vendor. Insiders say objections have also been raised by the